



BY ROMAL SHETTY

MISSION 2047: A TECH-DRIVEN INDIA

As the latest Budget lays emphasis on developing India's tech know-how in every walk of life and economy, its future looks brighter than most of its peers

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AT THE WORLD Economic Forum summit held in Davos earlier this year, we witnessed the euphoria around 'this is India's century'. Undoubtedly, this is a consequence of India's favourable policy regime, economic and demographic fundamentals and the resilience demonstrated by the nation during Covid-19. As the fine print of Budget 2023-24 becomes clear, I feel confident about how we can address the challenges of contemporary India by unleashing the full potential of its people by leveraging technology.

The vision of a "tech-driven and knowledge-based economy with strong public finances", and a commitment to sustainability, was amply evident in the Budget announcements. The steps unveiled to make India future-ready through skilling, green initiatives and the use of tech are welcome. While these building blocks will undoubtedly propel India towards its *Amrit Kaal* goals, the country will reap the outcomes of these measures not just at 100 years of independence, but for many decades

to come. It is, in fact, an opportunity to accelerate India's development using tech that is most exciting.

Why is this important? Right from education and skilling and creating jobs to research for interdisciplinary business applications, ease of doing business and addressing social challenges, the building blocks of the new-age ecosystem are rooted in digital tech. India's ability to mass-ify tech and use it at scale is one of the key pillars driving economic growth.

TRANSFORMATION THROUGH TECH

Aadhaar, UPI and other platforms of the early India Stack are great examples of the catalysts powering India's transformation. Building on this, the use of existing components and developing new platforms is something that the government must be acknowledged for. For example, the government-backed Open Network for Digital Commerce can become a game changer in giving small merchants across India access to a decentralised e-commerce network. If successfully implemented, consumers will be able to discover any seller, product or service using any compatible app or platform. Similarly, the commitment to building an open-source agricultural digital stack will enable farmers to get better credit, plan crops, source inputs and more. This coupled with the agricultural accelerator programme has the potential to significantly transform

India's rural economy.

At Deloitte India, we have experienced the benefits of tech in rural India through our collaboration with the Haryana government. Deloitte had set up a fit-for-purpose model along with ASHA workers, medical experts, students and the government during Covid-19 to provide health-care in rural areas through remote monitoring. It also ran a pilot in three villages in Haryana to tackle anaemia under the *Anemia Mukht Mahilayen* programme. Telecom connectivity and the hundred 5G labs to be set up in engineering institutions can prove pivotal in priority areas like classroom education, precision farming, intelligent transport system and healthcare.

Tech will continue to evolve and a partnership between the government, academia and industry will be critical in developing innovations. It is commendable that the Budget makes a start with the Centre of Excellence framework for 5G and AI Labs to achieve the vision of "making AI in India and making AI work for India", along with incentivising development of new-age technologies.

EASY DOES IT

As India builds on its capabilities and competitiveness, it will continue to move up the value chain. There are many possibilities lying in wait for India. For instance, managing drones like an air traffic controller for a firm in another country, or providing cybersecurity globally from India are